these Ijtemas in Pakistan were also useful propaganda tools. Like any conference they acted as media events as well as illustrating the hosting body's strength, appeal and organizational abilities. They also provided a forum for disseminating key messages, and Lashkar used them to narrate success stories about its jihad campaigns to groups from different parts of the world.[68] Finally, these Ijtemas promoted the concept of the pan-Islamic umma and provided evidence of Lashkar's international appeal.[69] The Urdu publication *Jang* reported that mujahideen from over fifty countries attended Lashkar's 1998 Ijtema.[70] This may be an exaggeration, but even if it were half that number, that still demonstrates an impressive transnational appeal. According to Ahmed Rashid, the renowned Pakistani journalist and author who attended several of Lashkar's annual Ijtemas, the group was formidably well organized internationally. He noted that foreign attendees to these events came from locations including Chechnya, Tajikistan, China, Afghanistan, Sudan, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and the Middle East.[71] Boasting hyperbolically about its international presence, the invitation to the 1998 Ijtema proclaimed, 'That is to say, you can go to any jehadi front in the world and you will find Markazul Dawa Wal Irshad mujahideen crushing the infidels and destroying the fortresses of the devil, God willing.'[72] During the 1999 Ijtema speakers extolled jihad against India and America, while Taliban delegates from Afghanistan vowed never to hand over Osama bin Laden to the United States.[73] Current and retired members of the government and ISI attended as well, including former ISI Director General Hamid Gul.[74] Their presence spoke to Lashkar's close relationship with the ISI and growing presence within the country. It also represented a shift begun by the government during the mid 1990s, which was driven by the ISI, to stop apologizing for the Kashmir jihad.[75] By the end of the decade jihadi groups were more visible than ever before. In 1998 the Governor of Punjab Shahid Hamid visited Muridke to 'congratulate the Lashkar-e-Taiba on the martyrdom of their 418 mujahids in Indian-occupied Kashmir.' The Federal Minister for Information, the Provincial Law Minister and the Minister for Education accompanied him. Saeed told the press that the visit would help to dispel the impression that Lashkar was a terrorist organization.[76] Of course it was exactly that by this time, as well as a prolific social welfare provider. In addition to having multiple faces, by the